
Accepted: the g-pawn defenses

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KG-01 - Nf3 prevents an immediate queen check on h4. Black uses ...g5 to keep f4, so h4 attacks the supporting chain. After ...g4 the knight must move; Ne5 takes an active central post.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop Bc4 or d4 according to Black's reply, then solve king safety. The h-file may open for either side; do not assume the rook alone creates an attack.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

Black can play ...Nf6 against e4 and ...d6 against Ne5. Count the defenders of e4 before chasing f7.

RECOGNITION TEST

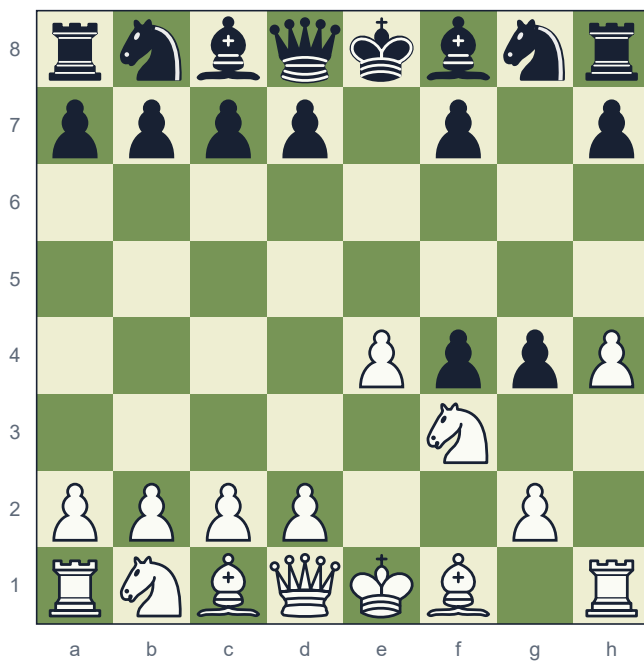
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KG-01 / The main choice: meet ...g5 with h4

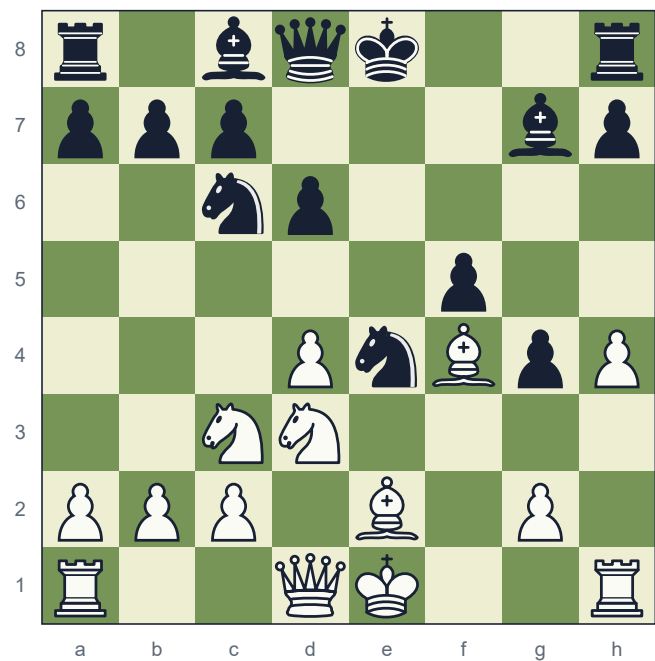
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 Nf6 6. d4 d6 7. Nd3 Nxe4 8. Bxf4 Nc6 9. Nc3 f5 10. Be2 Bg7

Authored anchor ends after 5. Ne5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Nf3 prevents an immediate queen check on h4. Black uses ...g5 to keep f4, so h4 attacks the supporting chain. After ...g4 the knight must move; Ne5 takes an active central post.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Bc4 or d4 according to Black's reply, then solve king safety. The h-file may open for either side; do not assume the rook alone creates an attack.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can play ...Nf6 against e4 and ...d6 against Ne5. Count the defenders of e4 before chasing f7.

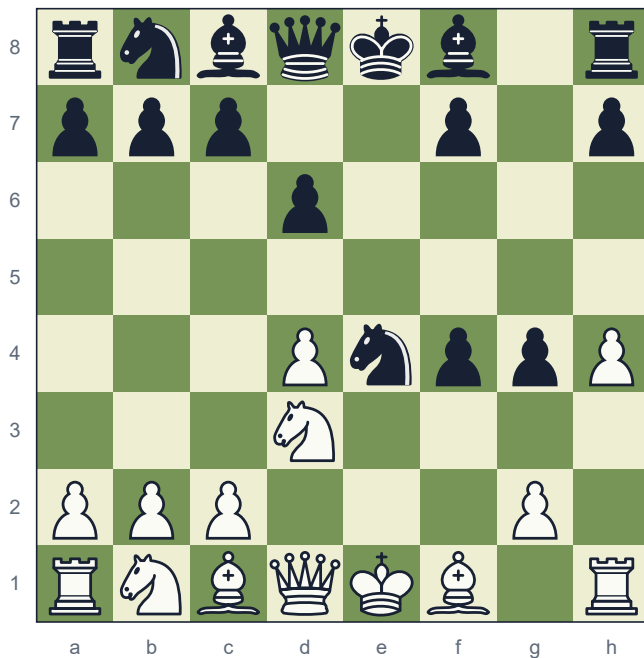
REMEMBER Attack the pawn chain, then move the attacked knight.

KG-02 / Kieseritzky: the developing ...Nf6

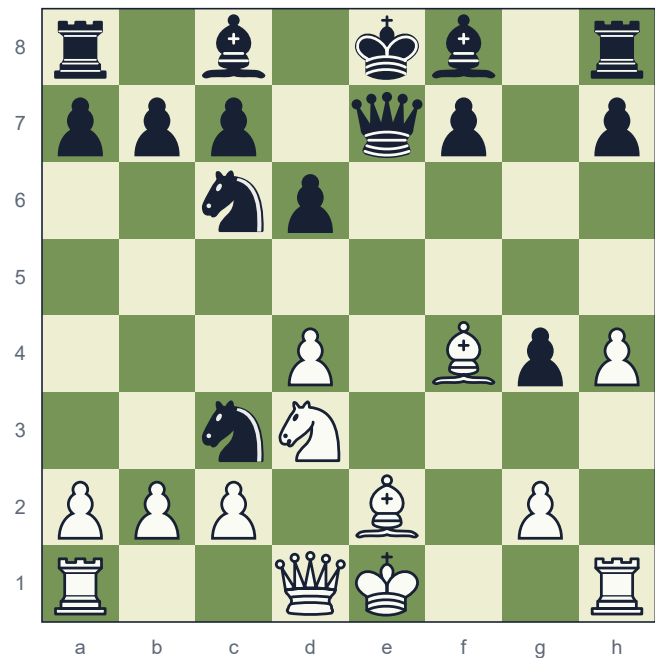
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 Nf6 6. d4 d6 7. Nd3 Nxe4 8. Bxf4 Qe7 9. Be2 Nc6 10. Nc3 Nxc3

Authored anchor ends after 8. Bxf4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The retreat Nd3 keeps the knight protected and allows the bishop to recover f4. Black takes e4, so material recovery alone has not won the opening.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Finish development and compare the open central files. Look for useful queen or knight pressure against the advanced e4 knight without overlooking a check.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's knight is active and your king remains central. A speculative attack on f7 can lose time against ...Bg7 and ...O-O.

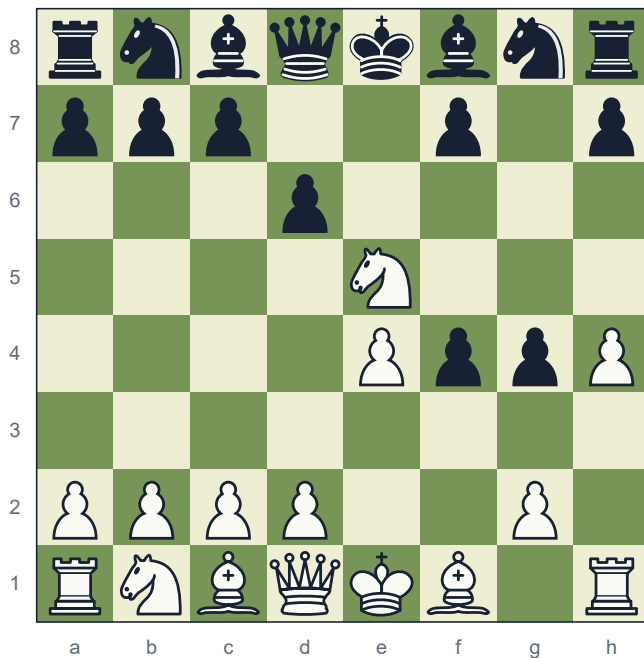
REMEMBER Count both sides' captures, not just the pawn you recovered.

KG-03 / Kieseritzky: an immediate ...d6

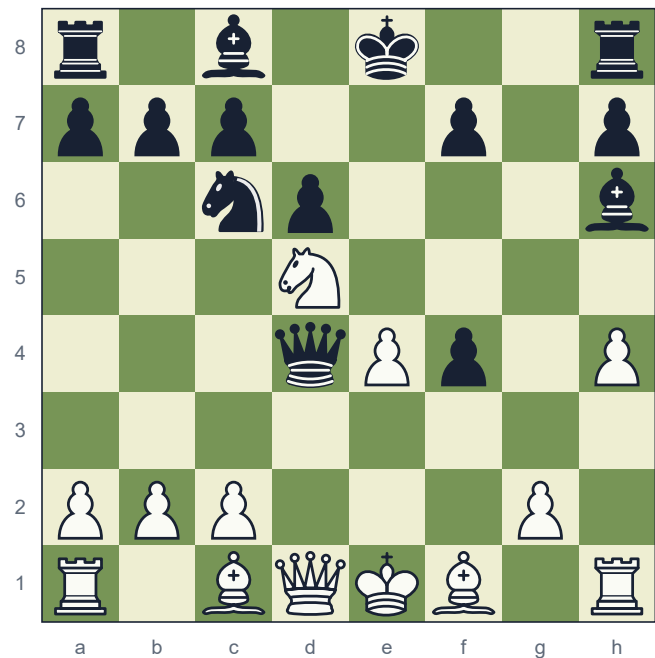
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 d6 6. Nxg4 Nc6 7. Nc3 Nf6 8. Nxf6+ Qxf6 9. d4 Bh6 10. Nd5 Qxd4

Authored anchor ends after 6. Nxg4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black attacks Ne5 with the d-pawn, but the knight can capture the advanced g4 pawn while escaping. This concrete resource is stronger than mechanically retreating to d3 in this exact position.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishops and build the center while checking whether the knight will be attacked again. Compare Black's bishop development with attempts to preserve f4.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A similar position with an extra black developing move can change the tactics. Do not treat Nxg4 as universal whenever ...d6 attacks Ne5.

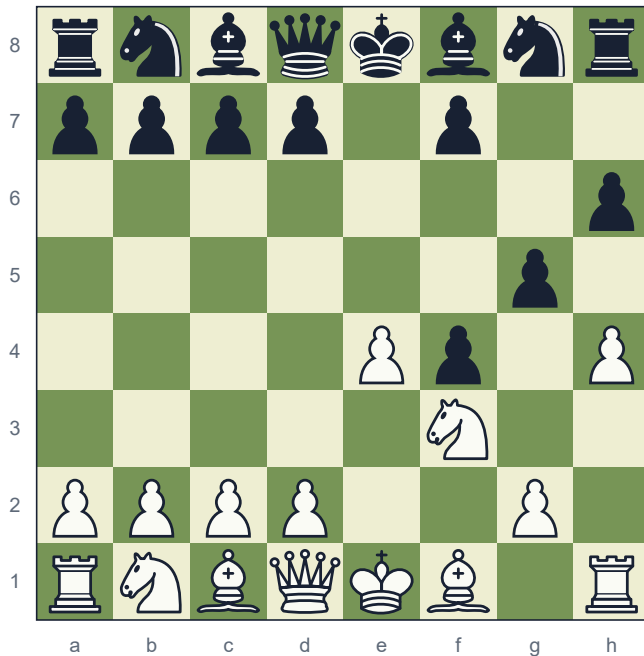
REMEMBER An attacked piece may escape by capturing a target.

KG-04 / Black reinforces with ...h6

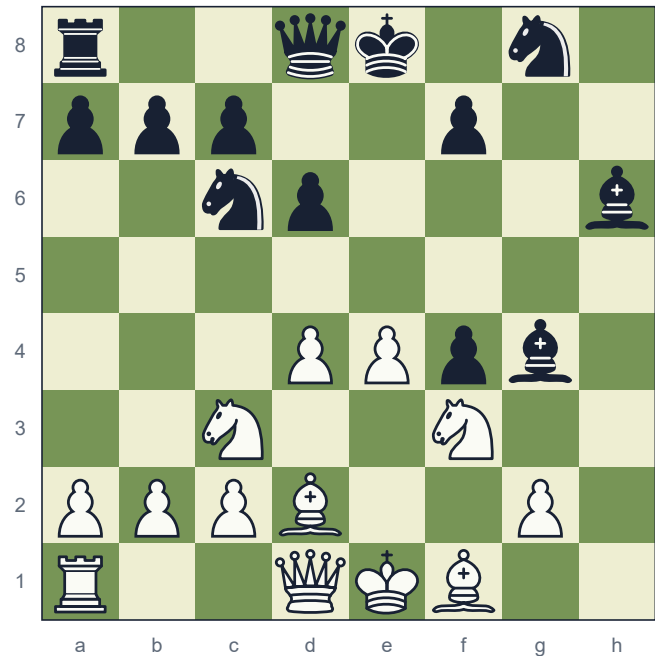
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. h4 h6 5. hxg5 Bg7 6. gxh6 Rxh6 7. Rxh6 Bxh6 8. d4 d6 9. Bd2 Bg4 10. Nc3 Nc6

Authored anchor ends after 5. hxg5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White captures on g5 immediately, testing the supporting pawn chain before building d4. The exact recapture matters because the h-file and rook on h8 can become tactically relevant.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Follow the printed continuation and finish development. Recount material after the whole exchange rather than assuming every pawn contact has an automatic recapture.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may develop with ...Bg7 or use the center. A careless capture can open a rook line against an undeveloped position.

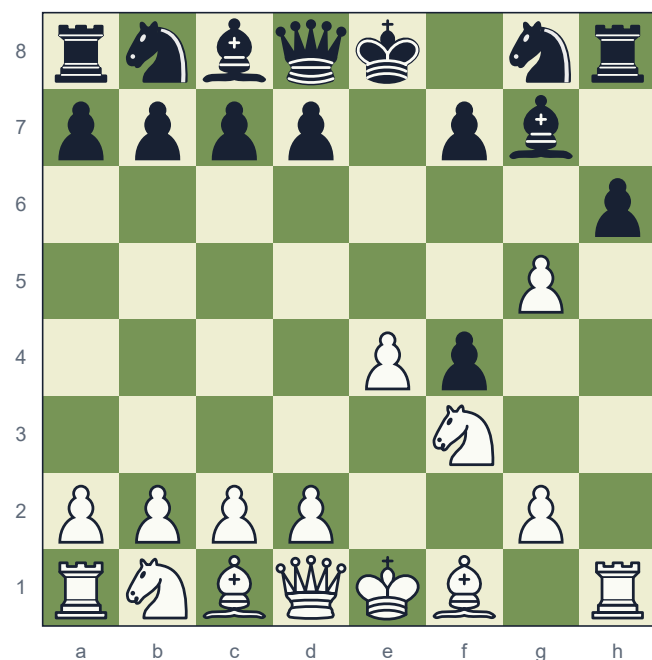
REMEMBER Calculate the h-file before choosing the recapture.

KG-05 / Black develops the bishop early

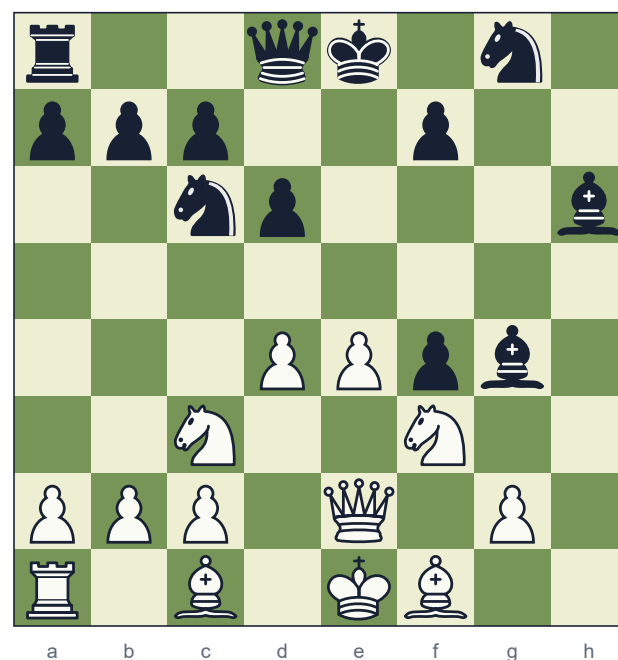
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. h4 Bg7 5. hxg5 h6 6. gxh6 Rxh6 7. Rxh6 Bxh6 8. Nc3 d6 9. Qe2 Nc6 10. d4 Bg4

Authored anchor ends after 6. gxh6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White's h-pawn captures on g5 and then on h6, removing two supporting pawns. The resulting position requires exact material accounting and a development plan.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the center and bishops, then choose king safety. Compare the pressure on the advanced h6 pawn with the usefulness of opening the h-file.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's g7 bishop and f4 pawn remain active factors. A pawn on h6 is not itself a mating attack.

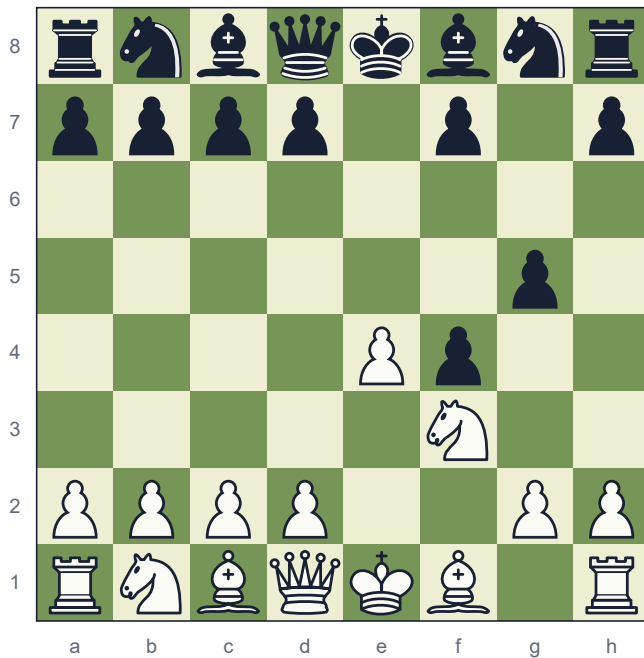
REMEMBER Track a pawn's new file after every capture.

KG-06 / Quiet alternative: the Vienna-style approach

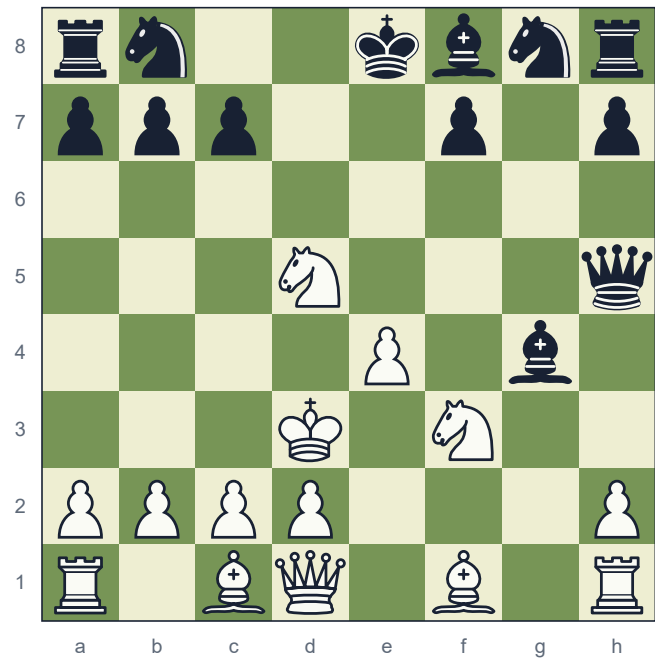
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. Nc3 g4 5. Ne5 d5 6. Nxd5 Qh4+ 7. Ke2 f3+ 8. gxf3 gxf3+ 9. Kd3 Qh5 10. Nxf3 Bg4

Authored anchor ends after 4. Nc3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Nc3 develops instead of immediately challenging g5. It protects e4 but permits Black to expand; this is an optional comparison, not the main h4 repertoire.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Meet threats to Nf3 concretely and use d4 when supported. Compare the resulting position with the h4 lines before choosing this alternative for real games.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A quick ...g4 gains a tempo against the knight. Quiet development does not make the advanced pawn chain disappear.

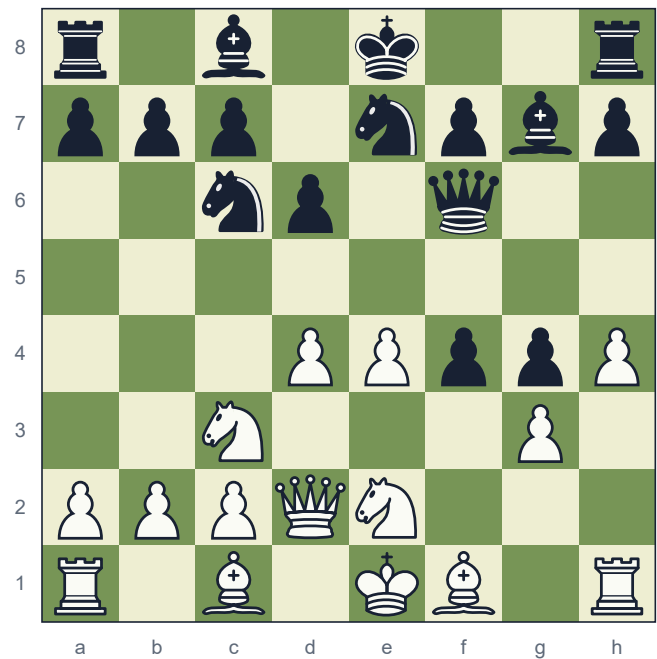
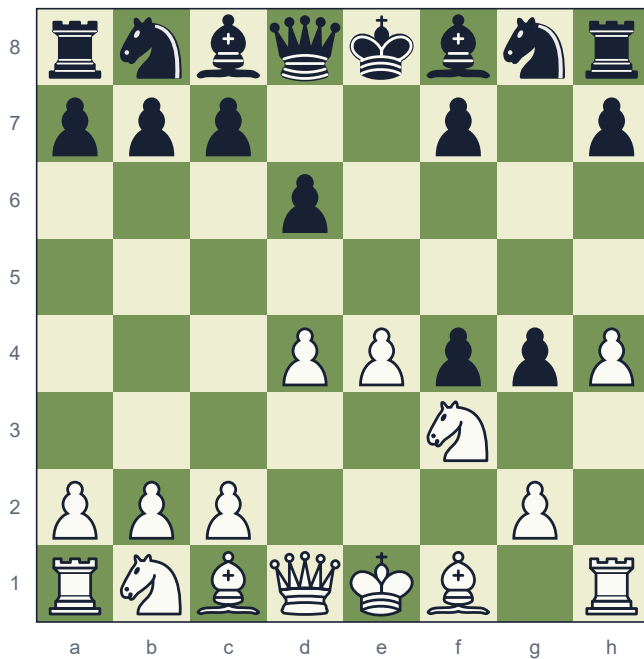
REMEMBER A development move can concede a forcing pawn tempo.

KG-07 / Fischer Defense: build the center

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 d6 4. d4 g5 5. h4 g4 6. Ng1 Qf6 7. Nc3 Ne7 8. Nge2 Bh6 9. Qd2 Nbc6 10. g3 Bg7

Authored anchor ends after 6. Ng1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Black's ...d6 controls e5, so the Kieseritzky knight jump is unavailable. Ng1 is a deliberate retreat preserving the knight after the g-pawn advance.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use the broad center and develop the bishops. The knight must return to play, often through e2 or h3 according to the concrete line.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Playing Ne5 as if ...d6 were absent simply leaves the knight vulnerable. Black also threatens to complete development while you spend another knight tempo.

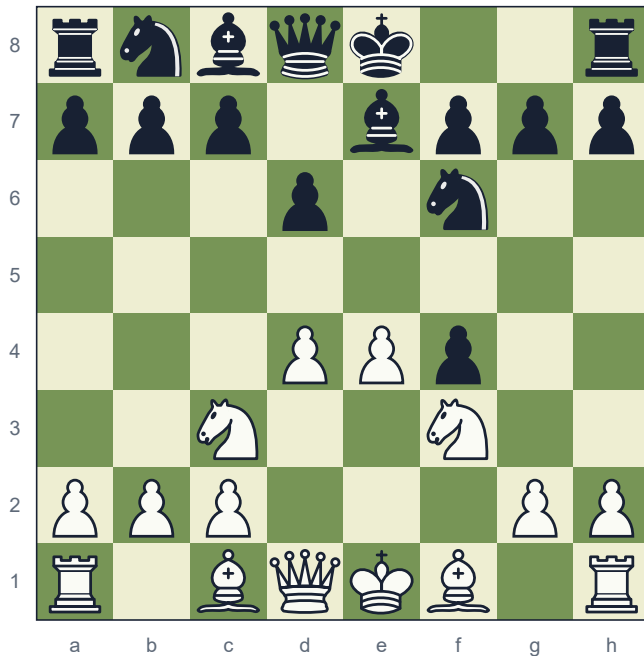
REMEMBER ...d6 changes the knight's retreat square.

KG-08 / Fischer Defense: Black develops first

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 d6 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Be7 6. Bxf4 O-O 7. Bd3 Nc6 8. a3 Bg4 9. Be3 Bh5 10. O-O Ng4

Authored anchor ends after 6... O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black returns the extra pawn to develop smoothly. White obtains a center and normal pieces, but should not expect a forced attack.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Choose Bd3 or Be2, castle and reinforce e4. A central break may be more useful than an early kingside pawn storm.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can challenge the center with ...d5 or ...c5. An undefended e4 pawn can become the target of ...Nxe4 tactics.

REMEMBER If the pawn is returned, play the resulting position.

Work through KG-01

7. ND3

Places the knight on d3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

8. BXF4

The bishop captures a pawn on f4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

9. NC3

Places the knight on c3, attacking knight on e4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10. BE2

Places the bishop on e2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Nf3 prevents an immediate queen check on h4. Black uses ...g5 to keep f4, so h4 attacks the supporting chain. After ...g4 the knight must move; Ne5 takes an active central post. Develop Bc4 or d4 according to Black's reply, then solve king safety. The h-file may open for either side; do not assume the rook alone creates an attack.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Accepted: central and developing defenses

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KG-09 - Black exchanges central pawns and develops toward the returned material. Bc4 creates pressure while White builds a useful d4 center.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Castle, develop Nc3 and decide whether the f4 pawn is worth a separate tempo. A lead in development is valuable only if the pieces have targets.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

Black can exchange pieces and neutralize the initiative. Do not sacrifice more material merely because the opening began as a gambit.

RECOGNITION TEST

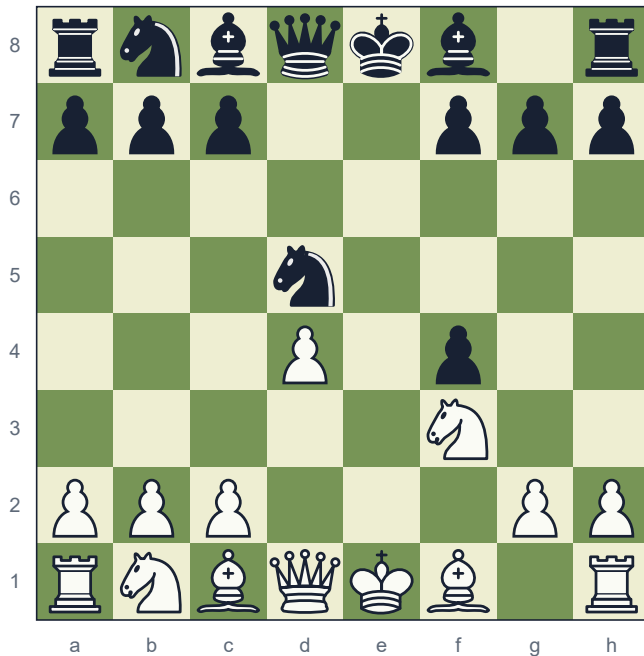
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KG-09 / Modern Defense: ...d5 at once

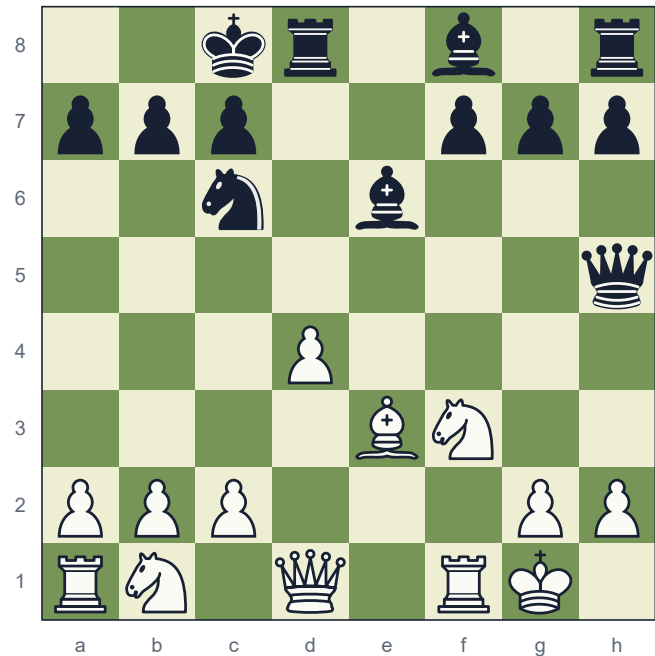
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 d5 4. exd5 Nf6 5. d4 Nxd5 6. Bc4 Be6 7. Bxd5 Qxd5 8. O-O Nc6 9. Bxf4 O-O-O 10. Be3 Qh5

Authored anchor ends after 6. Bc4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black exchanges central pawns and develops toward the returned material. Bc4 creates pressure while White builds a useful d4 center.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Castle, develop Nc3 and decide whether the f4 pawn is worth a separate tempo. A lead in development is valuable only if the pieces have targets.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can exchange pieces and neutralize the initiative. Do not sacrifice more material merely because the opening began as a gambit.

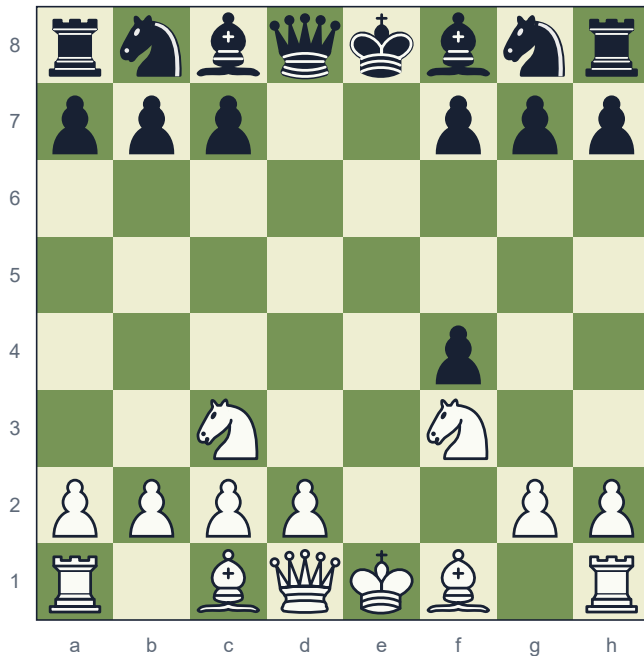
REMEMBER Central counterplay can matter more than retaining the extra pawn.

KG-10 / Modern Defense: the queen recaptures

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 d5 4. exd5 Qxd5 5. Nc3 Qd8 6. d4 Bd6 7. Bc4 Bf5 8. O-O Nc6 9. Nb5 Nge7 10. Nh4 Be6

Authored anchor ends after 6. d4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Nc3 develops while attacking the queen. After her retreat White has gained time, but still needs to complete development and address f4.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Bring out the bishops, castle and keep the central pawns supported. The extra developing tempo should become piece activity rather than premature queen moves.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A queen chased once is not trapped. Black can catch up if White spends several moves trying to hunt it.

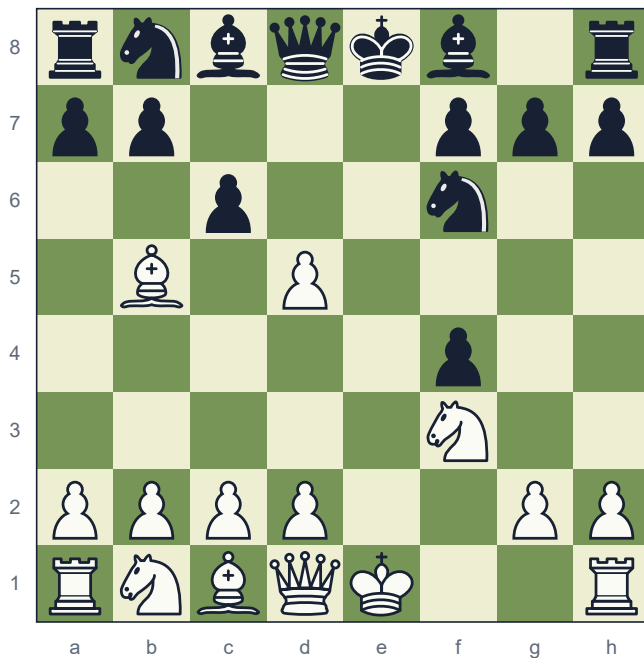
REMEMBER Gain a tempo and spend it on development.

KG-11 / Abbazia: an early pawn exchange

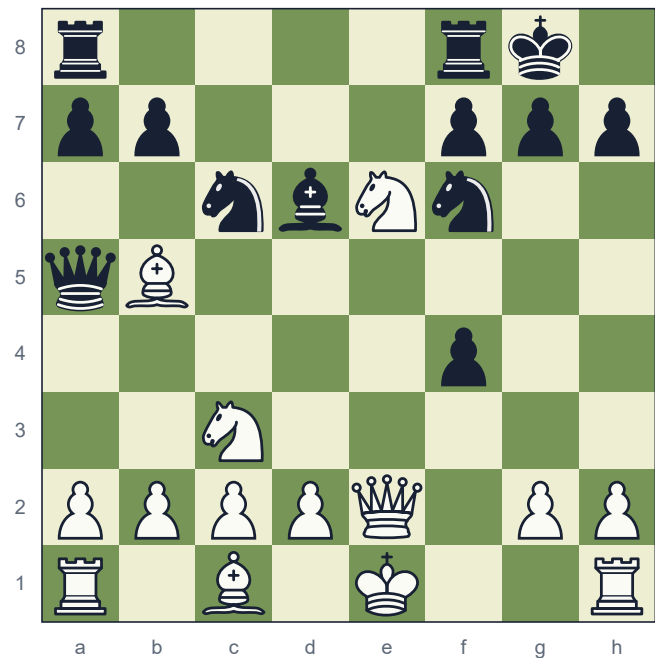
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 d5 4. exd5 Nf6 5. Bb5+ c6 6. dxc6 Nxc6 7. Nc3 Bd6 8. Qe2+ Be6 9. Ng5 O-O 10. Nxe6 Qa5

Authored anchor ends after 6... Nxc6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The checking bishop invites ...c6, after which exchanges accelerate Black's development too. This optional branch teaches why a check is not necessarily a gain of time.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Withdraw the bishop safely when attacked and establish d4 if the position permits. Compare activity and king safety before claiming a material gain.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's knights have natural central squares and open lines. Taking more pawns can leave White behind in development.

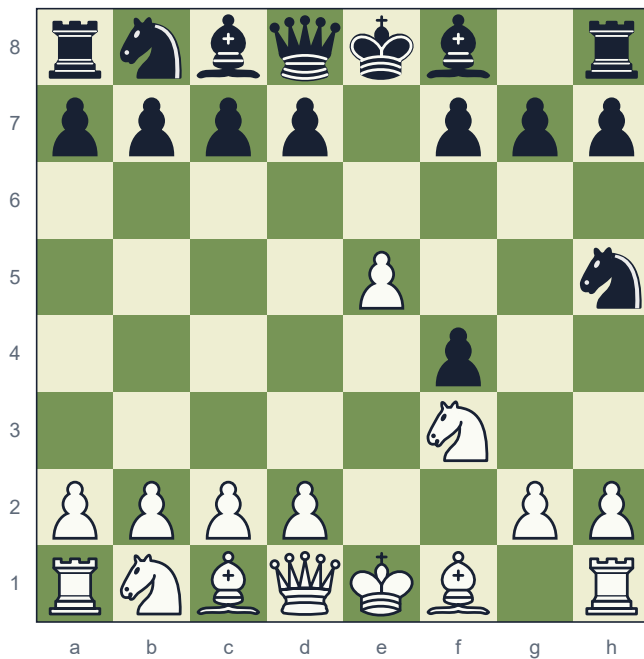
REMEMBER A check can help the defender develop.

KG-12 / Schallop Defense

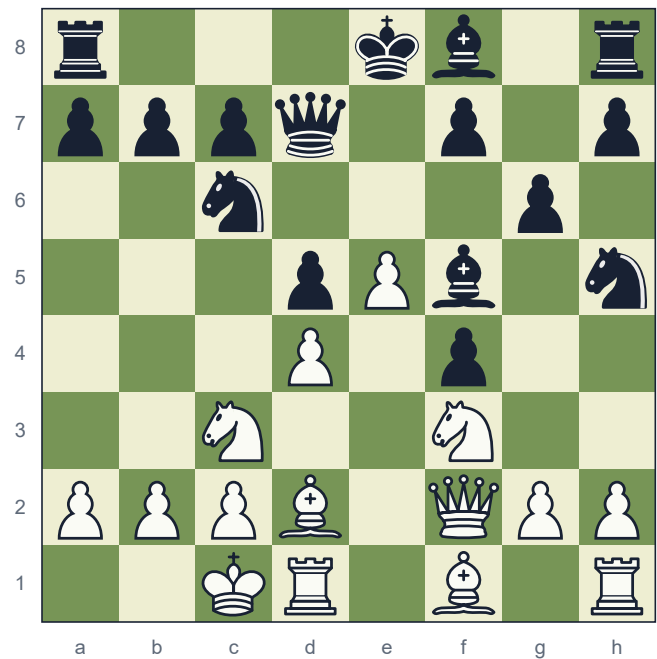
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e5 Nh5 5. d4 d6 6. Qe2 d5 7. Nc3 Nc6 8. Bd2 Bf5 9. O-O-O Qd7 10. Qf2 g6

Authored anchor ends after 5... d6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

e5 attacks the knight, which heads to h5 to help preserve f4. Black challenges the advanced e-pawn with ...d6.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Bc4 or Bd3 as appropriate and examine exd6 only after considering the recapture. White must maintain central support while the knight is offside.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The h5 knight still influences f4 and g3. Do not push g4 without calculating ...fxg3 en passant when legal and the effect on king safety.

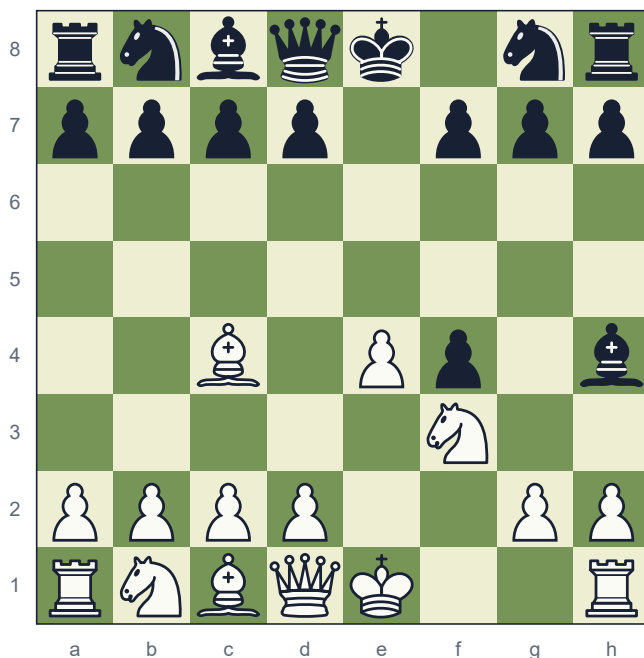
REMEMBER An offside knight may still perform a concrete defensive job.

KG-13 / Cunningham: meet the bishop check

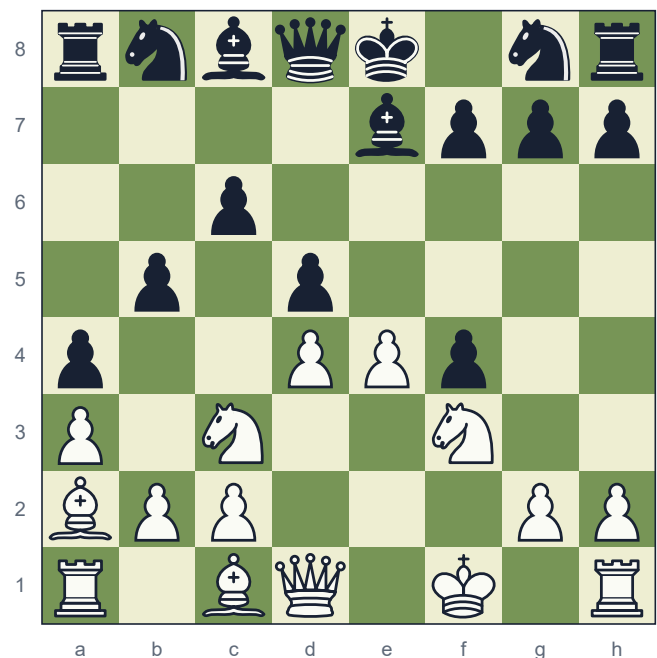
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 Be7 4. Bc4 Bh4+ 5. Kf1 c6 6. Nc3 b5 7. Bb3 a5 8. a3 Be7 9. d4 a4 10. Ba2 d5

Authored anchor ends after 5. Kf1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The bishop reaches h4 with check along the diagonal to e1. Kf1 answers it without pushing more kingside pawns, but permanently gives up castling.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop d4, Nc3 and the queen bishop while finding a safe place for the king. Treat rook coordination as a task; castling is no longer available.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can open the center with ...d5. Do not continue a routine castling plan after the king has moved.

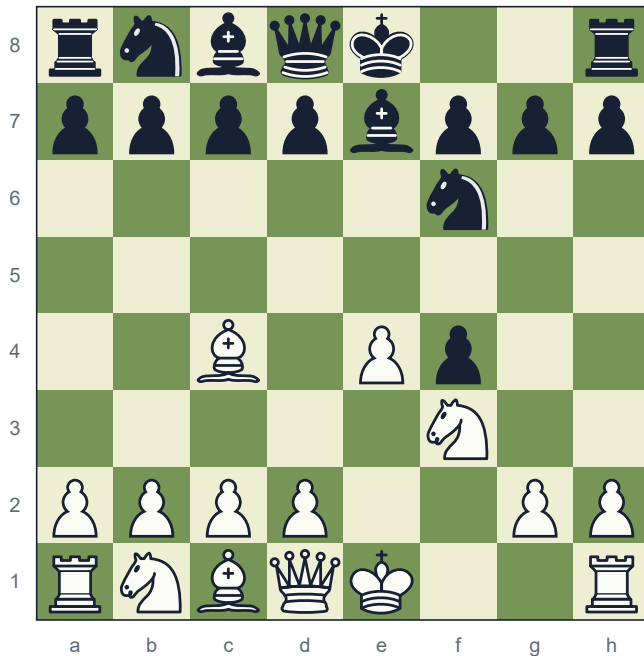
REMEMBER Surviving the check changes the whole king-safety plan.

KG-14 / Cunningham: Black chooses ...Nf6

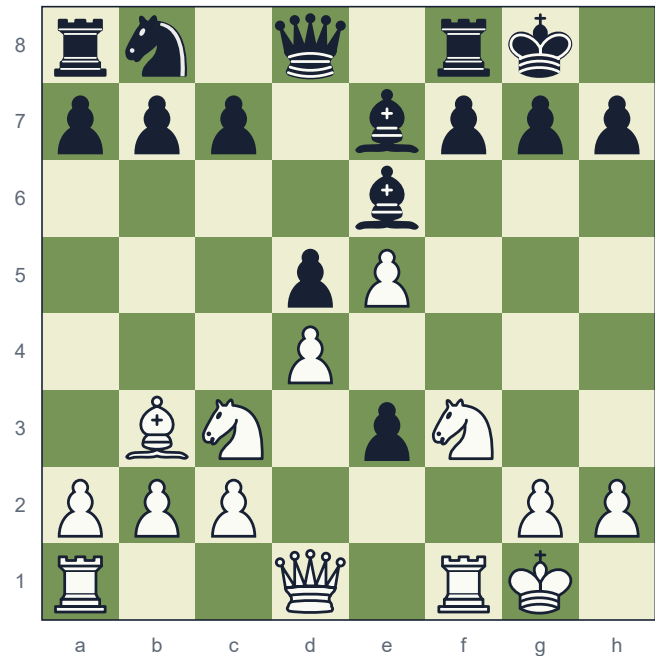
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 Be7 4. Bc4 Nf6 5. e5 Ng4 6. O-O O-O 7. d4 d5 8. Bb3 Ne3 9. Bxe3 fxe3 10. Nc3 Be6

Authored anchor ends after 5... Ng4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White gains space with e5 and Black places the knight actively. The g4 knight can create threats against e5 or f2; its location is more important than a general developing rule.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use d4 and careful development. Before castling, check the tactical relation between the knight, the f-pawn deficit and the bishop on c4.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Bxf7+ is not automatically sound. Black's king may survive while your pieces lack support.

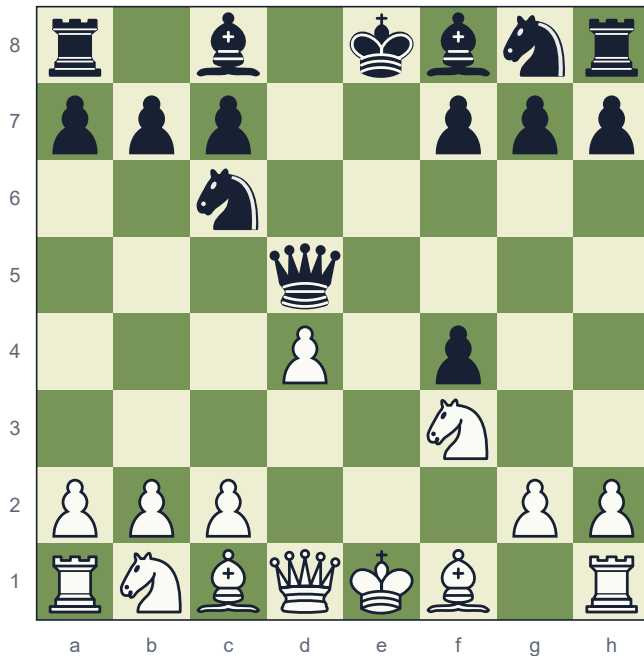
REMEMBER Count attackers and defenders on f2 as well as f7.

KG-15 / The ...Nc6 developing defense

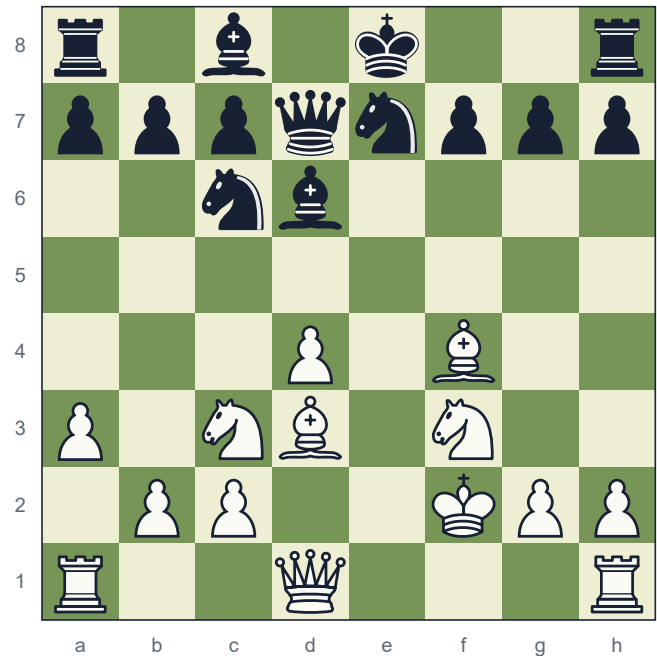
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 Nc6 4. d4 d5 5. exd5 Qxd5 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 Qe6+ 8. Kf2 Nge7 9. Bxf4 Qd7 10. a3 Bd6

Authored anchor ends after 6. Nc3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops and then hits the center. Nc3 gains a queen tempo, but the exchanges also release Black's pieces.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and compare queen retreats before choosing a bishop square. A broad center is useful only while it remains defended.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can answer a threat with a check or a capture. Verify the queen's active squares before assuming a free attack.

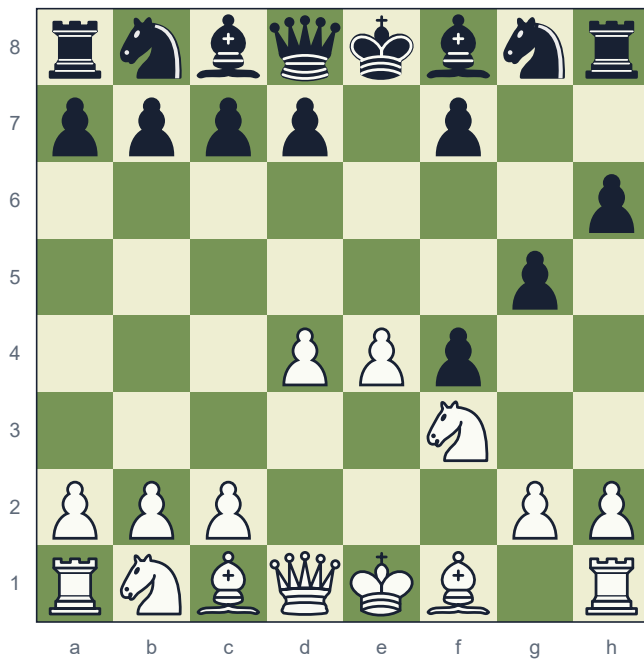
REMEMBER Development with tempo must still be tactically safe.

KG-16 / The ...h6 waiting move

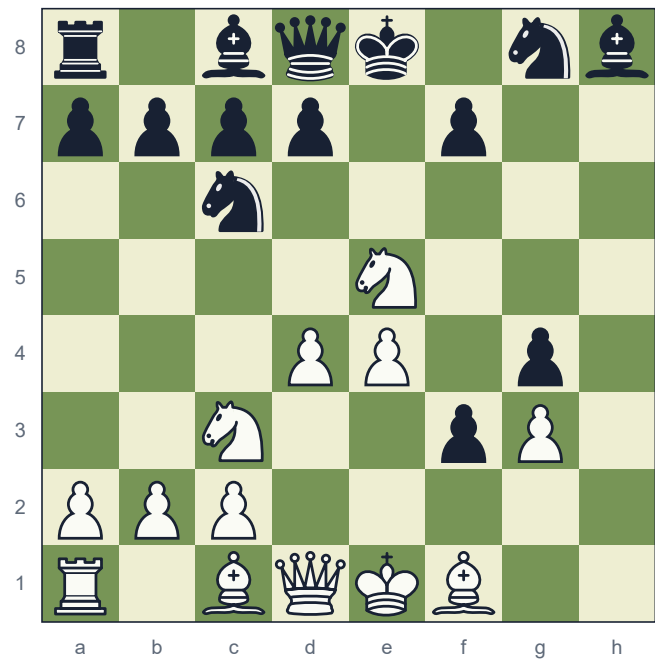
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 h6 4. d4 g5 5. h4 Bg7 6. hxg5 hxg5 7. Rxh8 Bxh8 8. g3 Nc6 9. Nc3 g4 10. Ne5 f3

Authored anchor ends after 5. h4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black prepares to hold f4 with ...g5. White places d4 before challenging the supporting pawns. This reaches familiar themes by a different order.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Follow the h-file exchanges carefully and use the center to keep pieces active. Identify whether e5 remains available to your knight before responding to ...g4.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

...d6 changes that availability; ...Nf6 changes the pressure on e4. Do not memorize the knight jump independently of those moves.

REMEMBER Match the position, not just the opening name.

Work through KG-09

7. BXD5

The bishop captures a knight on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

8. O-O

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

9. BXF4

The bishop captures a pawn on f4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

10. BE3

Places the bishop on e3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black exchanges central pawns and develops toward the returned material. Bc4 creates pressure while White builds a useful d4 center. Castle, develop Nc3 and decide whether the f4 pawn is worth a separate tempo. A lead in development is valuable only if the pieces have targets.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Declined and countergambits

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KG-17 - White uses c3 to support d4 while the bishop keeps pressure on the king side. Exchanging in the center gives White space but opens lines.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop the bishops, castle and keep the d4-e4 center defended. Chase the bishop only when it improves the position, not just because it is visible.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

The c5-b6 bishop watches the sensitive f2 square. Capturing e5 at the wrong time may permit ...Qh4+ and a king attack.

RECOGNITION TEST

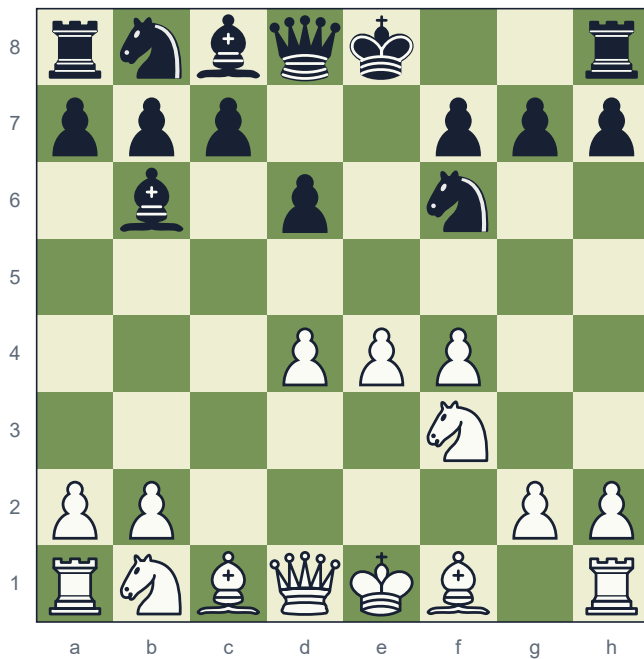
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KG-17 / Classical Declined: ...Bc5

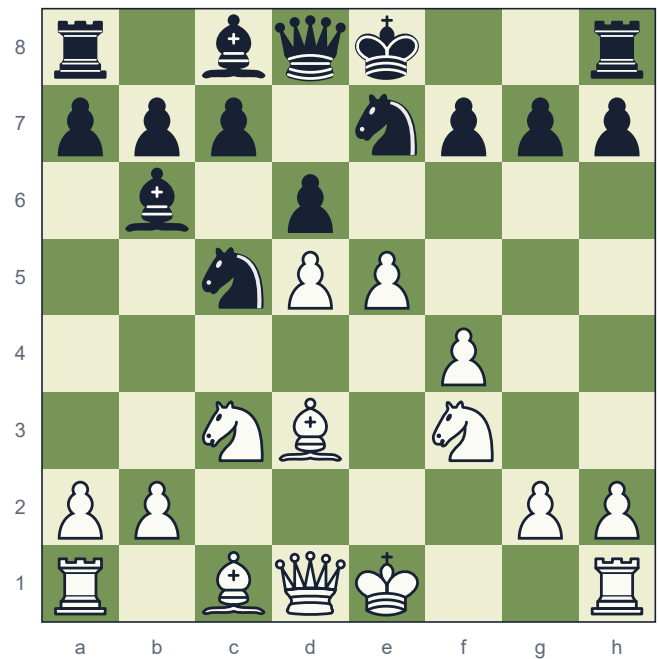
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 Bc5 3. Nf3 d6 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. cxd4 Bb6 7. Nc3 Nc6 8. e5 Nd7 9. d5 Ne7 10. Bd3 Nc5

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nc3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White uses c3 to support d4 while the bishop keeps pressure on the king side. Exchanging in the center gives White space but opens lines.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishops, castle and keep the d4-e4 center defended. Chase the bishop only when it improves the position, not just because it is visible.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The c5-b6 bishop watches the sensitive f2 square. Capturing e5 at the wrong time may permit ...Qh4+ and a king attack.

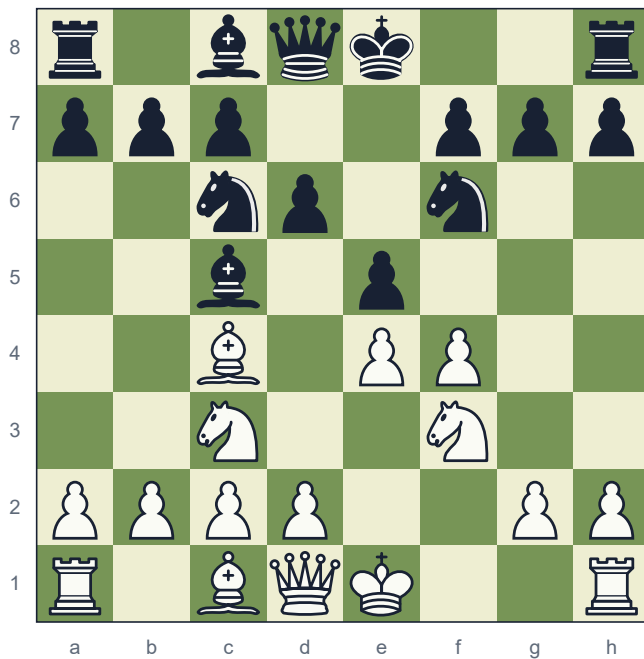
REMEMBER Respect the diagonal before taking e5.

KG-18 / Declined: ...Bc5 with ...Nc6

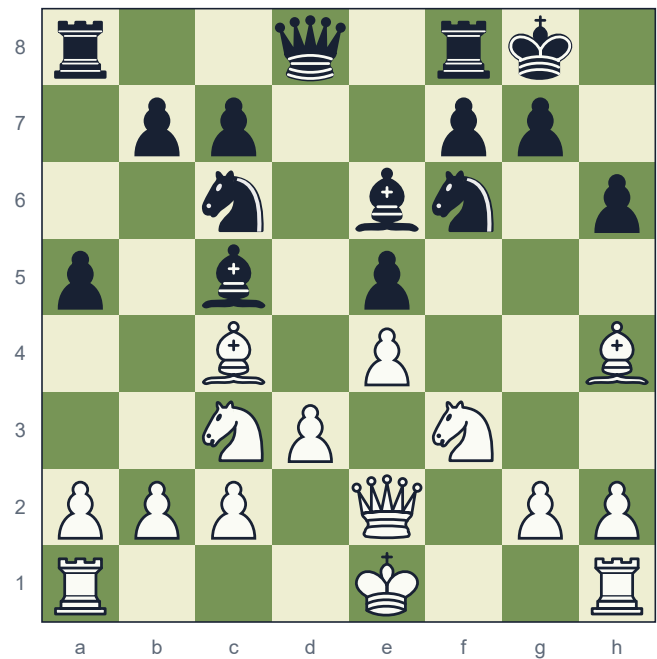
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 Bc5 3. Nf3 Nc6 4. Nc3 d6 5. Bc4 Nf6 6. d3 a5 7. fxe5 dxe5 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4 Be6 10. Qe2 O-O

Authored anchor ends after 6. d3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Both sides develop naturally. White keeps the option of a later f-pawn exchange without forcing an immediate central confrontation.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Castle, identify whether d4 is achievable and improve the least active piece. A quiet maneuvering game is a normal outcome of a gambit being declined.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can use ...Bg4 to pin Nf3 or open the center. Do not weaken the king with repeated pawn moves while pieces remain at home.

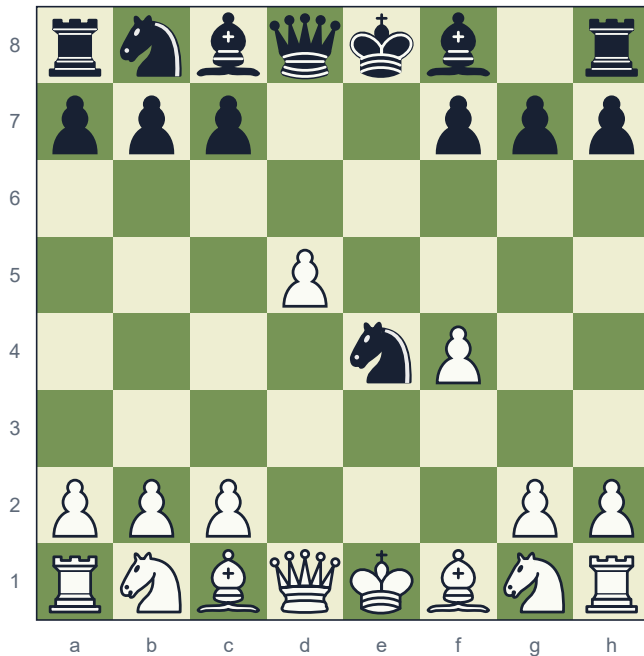
REMEMBER A declined gambit can become a normal development contest.

KG-19 / Falkbeer: the ...e4 wedge

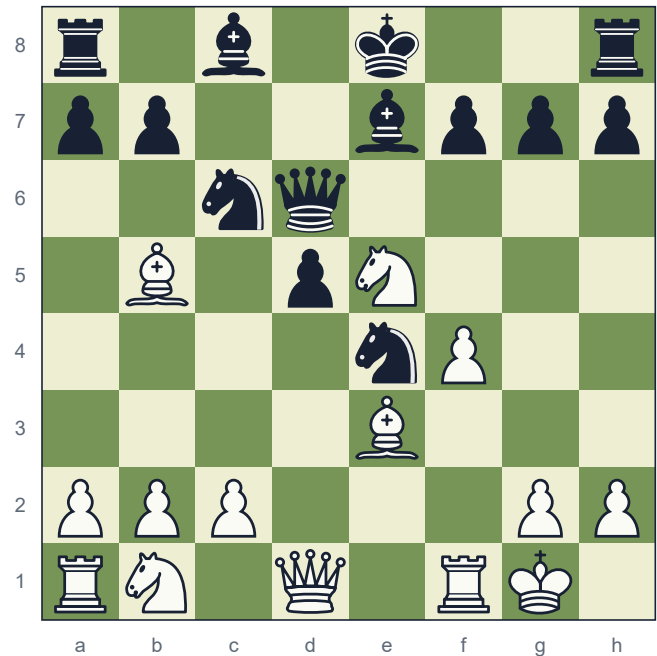
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 d5 3. exd5 e4 4. d3 Nf6 5. dxe4 Nxe4 6. Nf3 c6 7. Be3 cxd5 8. Bb5+ Nc6 9. O-O Be7 10. Ne5 Qd6

Authored anchor ends after 6. Nf3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black ignores the offered f-pawn and builds an advanced e4 wedge. d3 challenges it directly; exchanges change the position into a development battle.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishops and castle. Attack the central knight with useful moves only after checking tactics along the e-file.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's development can be rapid and the king remains on e1. A greedy attempt to keep every extra pawn can allow a central attack.

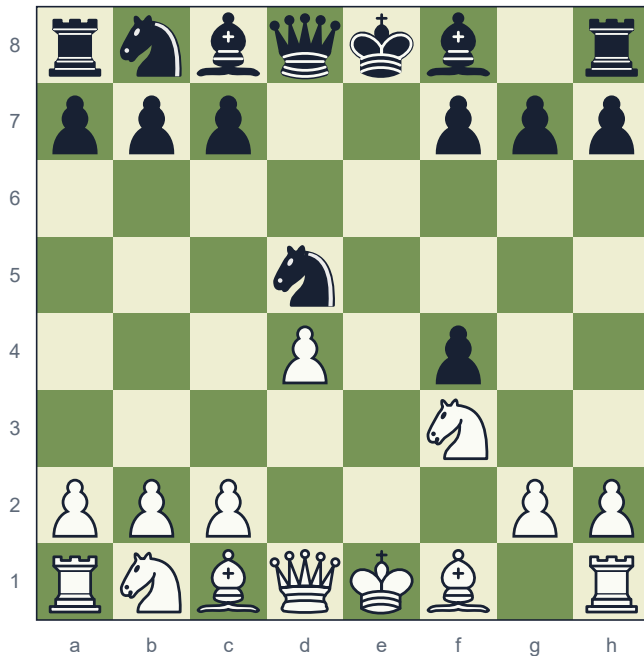
REMEMBER Challenge the wedge before it binds your pieces.

KG-20 / Falkbeer transposes to the Modern

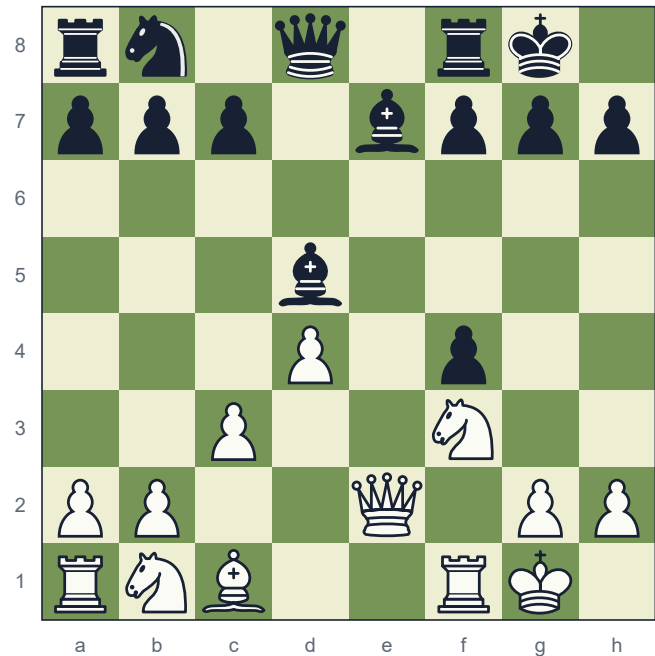
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 d5 3. exd5 exf4 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. d4 Nxd5 6. Bc4 Be6 7. Qe2 Bb4+ 8. c3 Be7 9. O-O O-O 10. Bxd5 Bxd5

Authored anchor ends after 6. Bc4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Capturing f4 after ...d5 produces the same type of position as the Modern Defense. The move order differs, but the central exchanges and piece tasks converge.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use the Modern Defense plan: development, king safety and pressure on active targets. Link the two routes on your repertoire map to reduce memorization.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

An extra tempo or a different knight square can break a transposition. Compare the actual board before importing a memorized continuation.

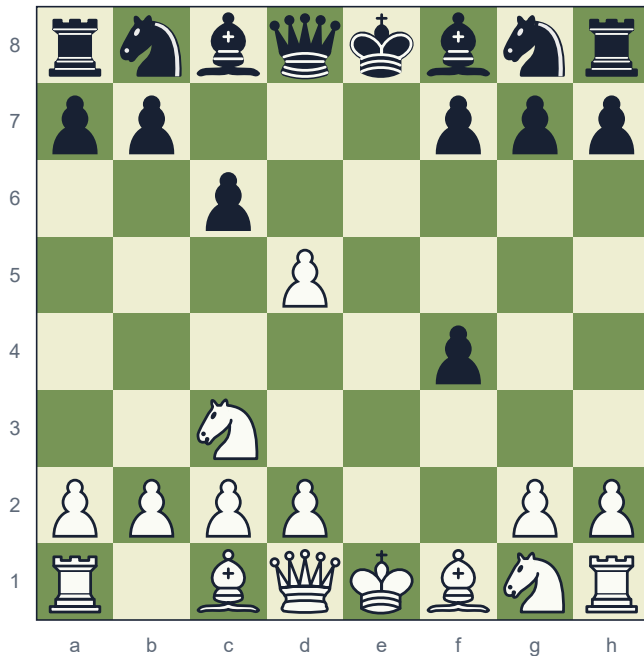
REMEMBER Transpose by position, including whose turn it is.

KG-21 / Falkbeer: ...c6 countergambit

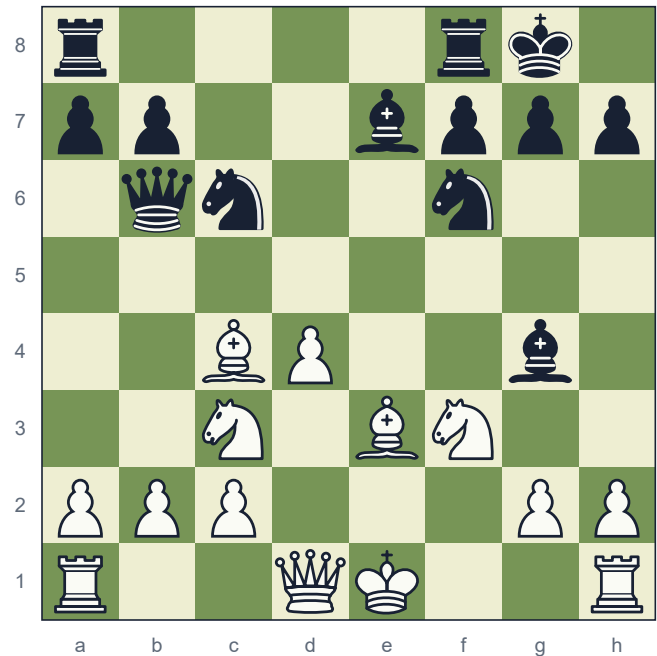
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 d5 3. exd5 c6 4. Nc3 exf4 5. Nf3 Be7 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. dxc6 Nxc6 8. d4 O-O 9. Bxf4 Bg4 10. Be3 Qb6

Authored anchor ends after 5. Nf3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White declines to spend another tempo taking a wing pawn and develops. Black sacrifices or returns material to obtain central and diagonal activity.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Stabilize the d-pawn if it is useful, otherwise let material return for development. Check the c-file and queen routes after any dxc6 capture.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Capturing c6 blindly can give Black easy development with ...Nxc6. The point is the resulting activity, not the label countergambit.

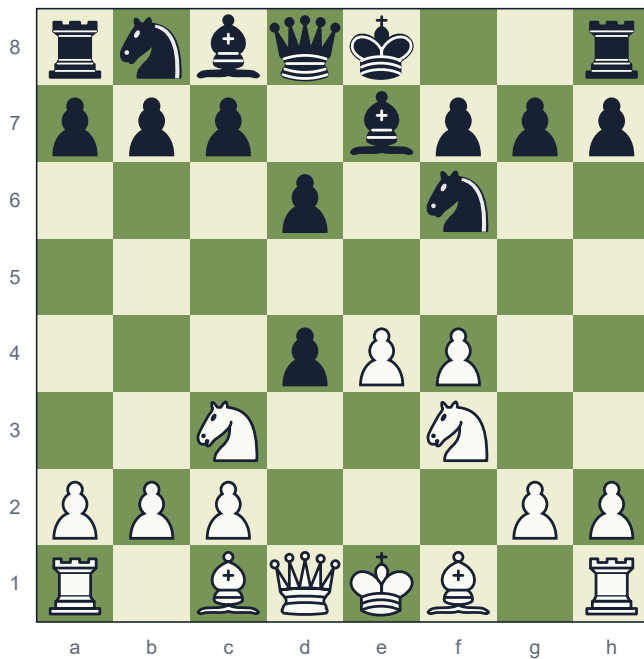
REMEMBER You do not have to accept a second gambit.

KG-22 / Declined with ...d6

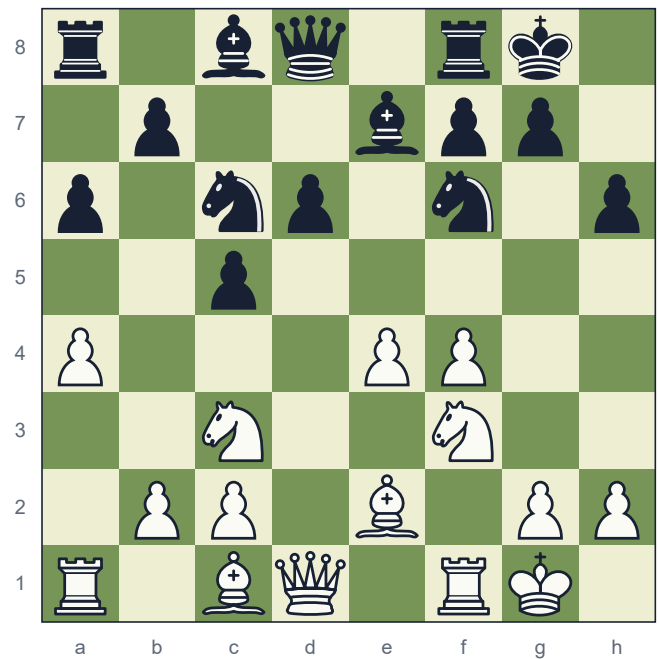
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 d6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Be7 5. d4 exd4 6. Nxd4 O-O 7. Be2 c5 8. Nf3 Nc6 9. O-O a6 10. a4 h6

Authored anchor ends after 6. Nxd4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black supports e5 and later exchanges it. White recaptures actively with the knight and gains space without an immediate sacrifice.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop a bishop, castle and decide whether f4-f5 or ordinary central pressure is justified. Keep the d4 knight safe from pawn attacks.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's restrained setup can still strike with ...d5. Do not assume that a passive-looking opening removes tactical obligations.

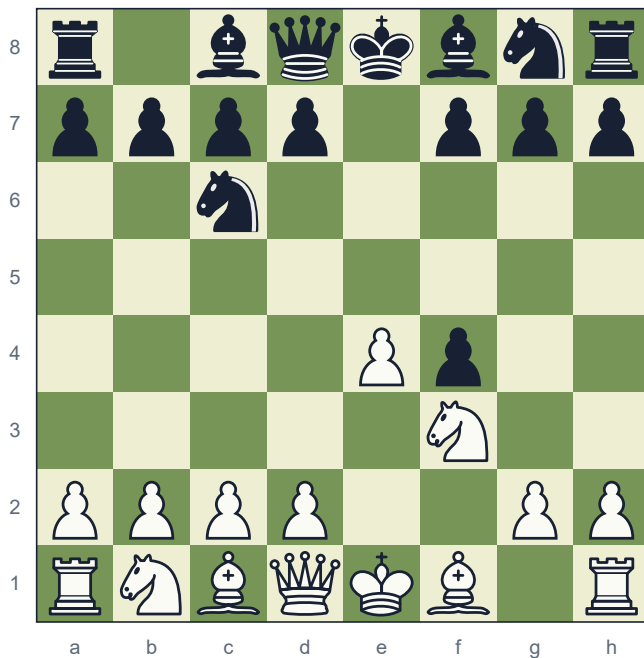
REMEMBER Gain space, then finish development.

KG-23 / Declined with ...Nc6

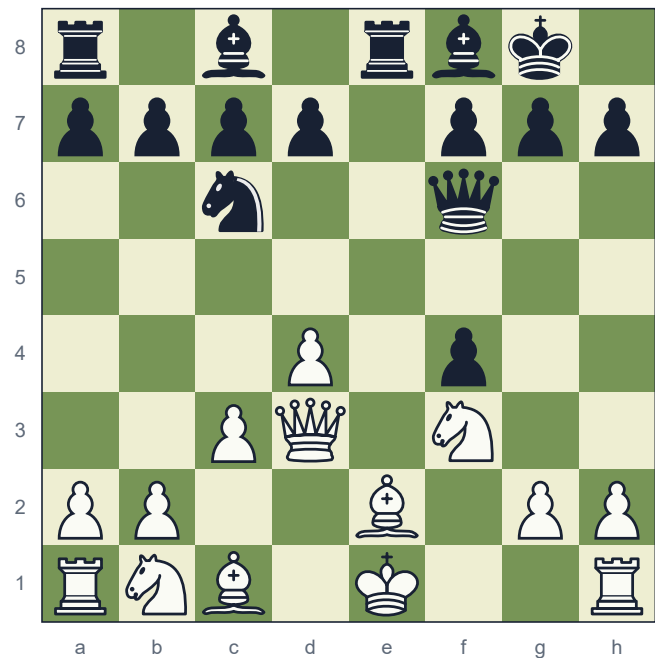
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 Nc6 3. Nf3 exf4 4. d4 Nf6 5. Qe2 Bd6 6. e5 O-O 7. Qd3 Re8 8. Be2 Bb4+ 9. c3 Bf8 10. exf6 Qxf6

Authored anchor ends after 4. d4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black may decline for one move and accept later. The position enters accepted-gambit territory with the queen knight already developed.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Track the pressure on d4 and e4, develop and answer ...g5 according to the actual center. A delayed capture changes available counterplay.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Memorizing only move two misses the transposition. Black may choose ...d5 before trying to defend f4.

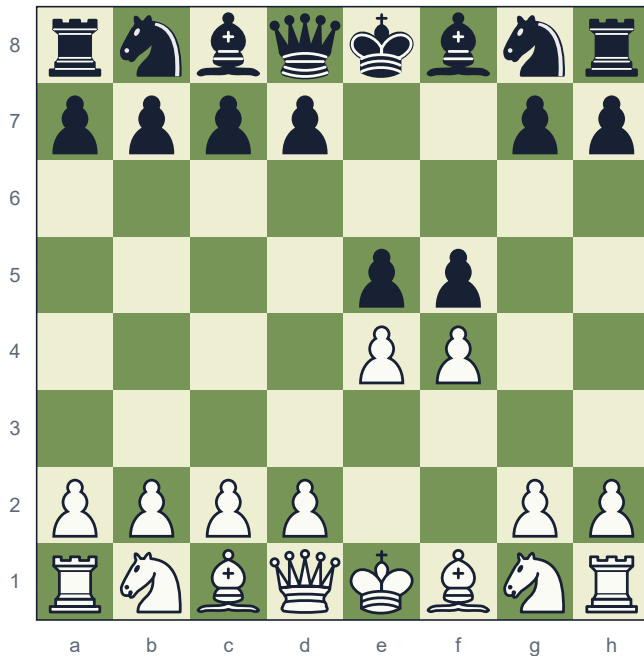
REMEMBER The opening can change family a move later.

KG-24 / The ...f5 countergambit

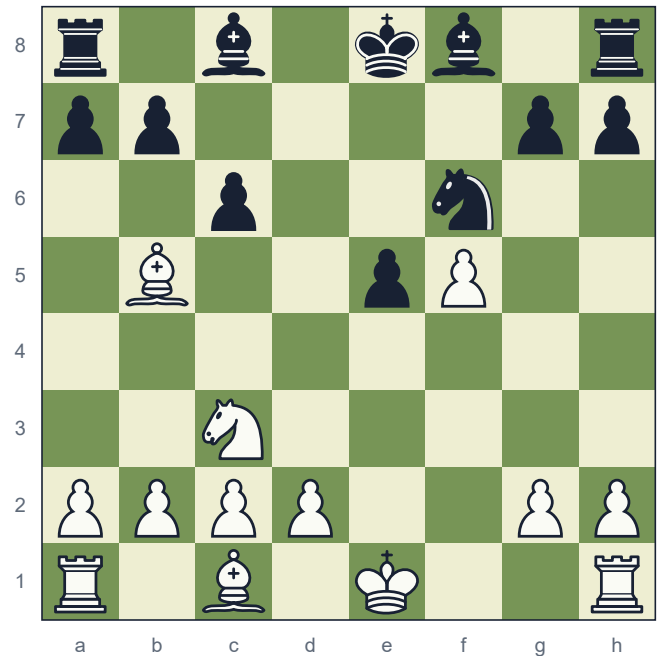
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e5 2. f4 f5 3. exf5 Qe7 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nc3 Nf6 6. fxe5 Nxe5 7. Nxe5 Qxe5+ 8. Qe2 d6 9. Qxe5+ dxe5 10. Bb5+ c6

Authored anchor ends after 3. exf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Capturing e5 is not the only way to respond to Black's central pawn action. exf5 exchanges the advanced f-pawn and leaves a concrete position to calculate.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Nf3 and choose d4 when safe. Study Black's checks and central captures before treating the extra pawn as secure.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The exposed kings and open diagonals make routine moves unreliable. A queen check can be more urgent than recovering another pawn.

REMEMBER Against countergambits, check forcing moves first.

Work through KG-17

7. NC3

Develops toward d5 and e4. Compare its central influence with the fact that it blocks the c-pawn.

8. E5

Places the pawn on e5, attacking knight on f6. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

9. D5

Places the pawn on d5, attacking knight on c6. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10. BD3

Places the bishop on d3. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White uses c3 to support d4 while the bishop keeps pressure on the king side. Exchanging in the center gives White space but opens lines. Develop the bishops, castle and keep the d4-e4 center defended. Chase the bishop only when it improves the position, not just because it is visible.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Alternatives and repertoire boundaries

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

KG-25 - Bc4 develops before Nf3 and therefore permits the queen check. Kf1 preserves the center but gives up castling. This is an alternative to learn after the main repertoire.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop Nf3 with a tempo against the queen if the position allows, then build d4 and coordinate the rook manually.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

An exposed king can be attacked through the center even if the queen retreats. Do not equate a queen tempo with complete compensation.

RECOGNITION TEST

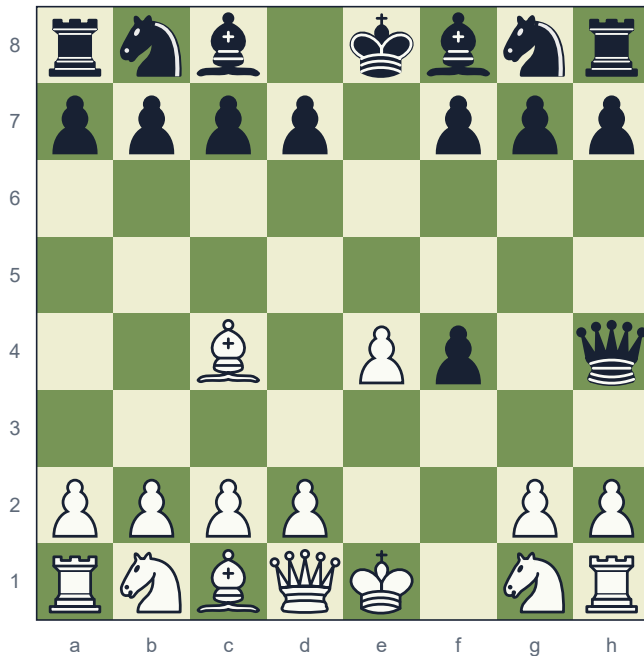
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

KG-25 / Bishop's Gambit: optional route

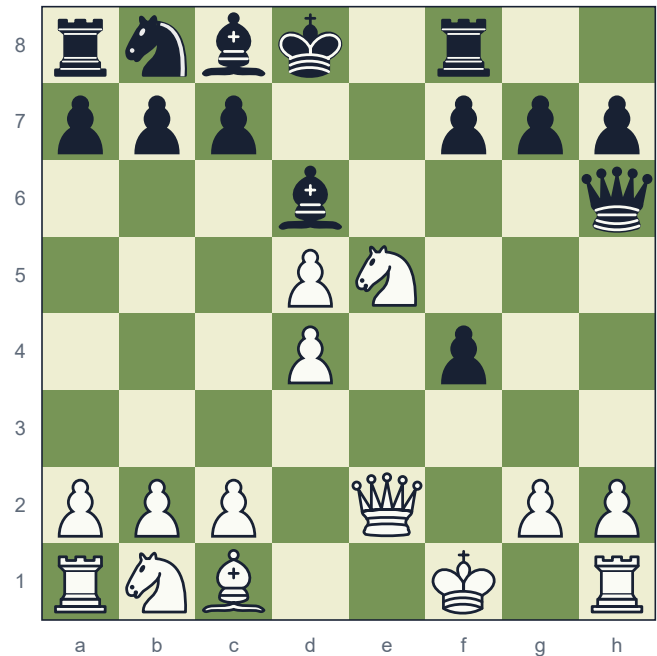
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Bc4 Qh4+ 4. Kf1 d5 5. Bxd5 Nf6 6. Nf3 Qh6 7. d4 Nxd5 8. exd5 Bd6 9. Qe2+ Kd8 10. Ne5 Rf8

Authored anchor ends after 4. Kf1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Bc4 develops before Nf3 and therefore permits the queen check. Kf1 preserves the center but gives up castling. This is an alternative to learn after the main repertoire.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Nf3 with a tempo against the queen if the position allows, then build d4 and coordinate the rook manually.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

An exposed king can be attacked through the center even if the queen retreats. Do not equate a queen tempo with complete compensation.

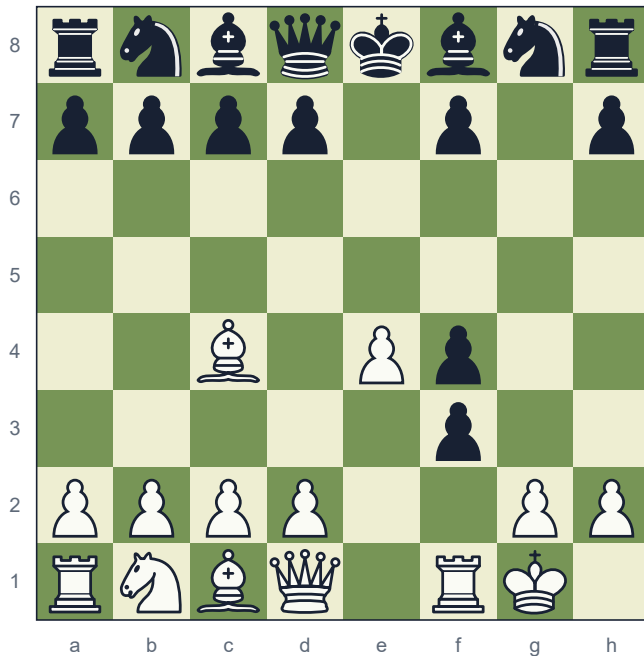
REMEMBER Bc4 first permits the check Nf3 would prevent.

KG-26 / Muzio: understand the sacrifice

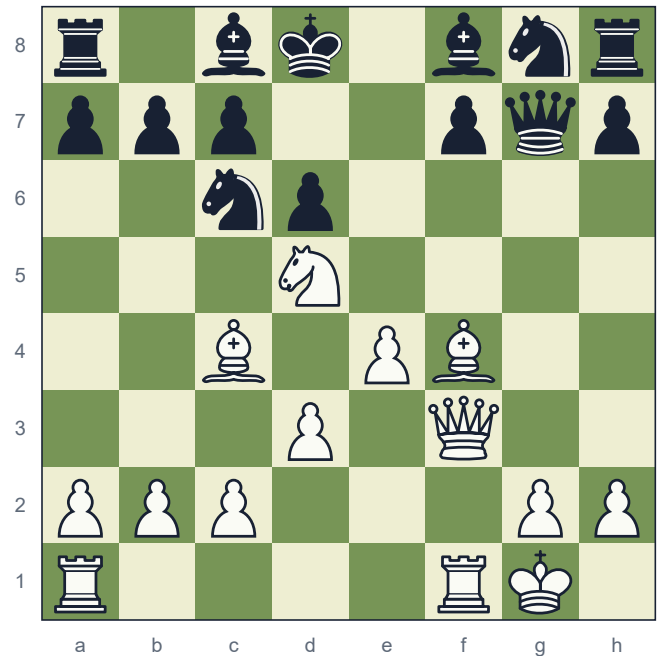
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. Nf3 g5 4. Bc4 g4 5. O-O gxf3 6. Qxf3 Qf6 7. d3 Nc6 8. Bxf4 d6 9. Nc3 Qg7 10. Nd5 Kd8

Authored anchor ends after 6. Qxf3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White deliberately gives a knight for rapid attacking development. This is a high-risk optional laboratory, not the recommended main repertoire for this course.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Calculate forcing play against f7 and e8 before making another sacrifice. Compare attack speed with Black's defensive resources and possible queen exchanges.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black need not cooperate with a famous mating pattern. If the attack stops, White is a piece down rather than merely a pawn down.

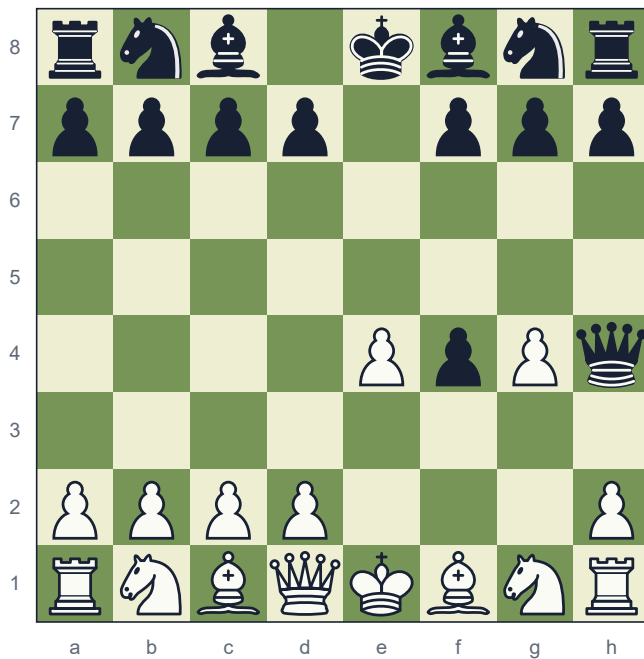
REMEMBER Distinguish a deliberate piece sacrifice from normal development.

KG-27 / Simple warning: the exposed king

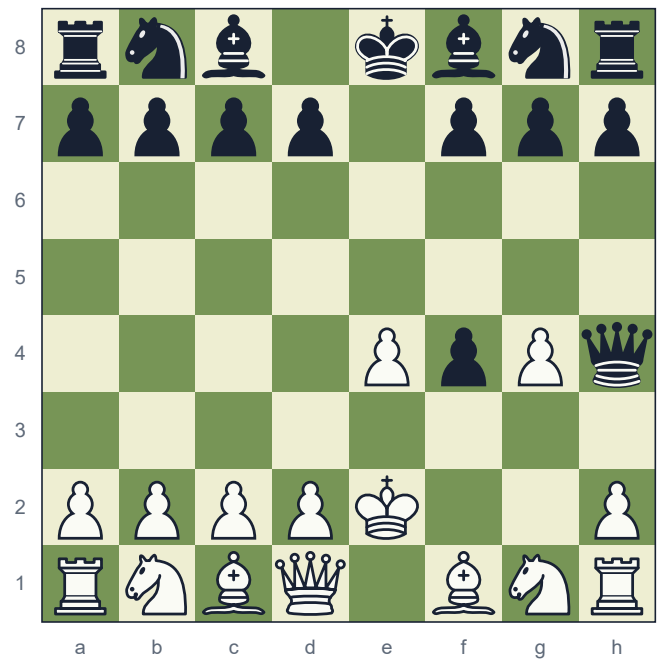
WARNING LINE - study the mistake

1. e4 e5 2. f4 exf4 3. g4 Qh4+ 4. Ke2

The anchor is the complete printed sequence.



Before your decision - White to move - in check



End of study line - Black to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The queen check on h4 forces a serious king-safety concession. Ke2 is a legal escape, so this is not checkmate, but White has lost castling and exposed the king before developing.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use this warning to learn why the main repertoire plays Nf3. Prove that Ke2 is legal, then explain why allowing the check was still a poor practical decision.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The desire to chase f4 ignores the h4-e1 diagonal. A legal escape does not make the opening choice good.

REMEMBER Check the queen's diagonal before chasing a pawn.

KG-28 / If Black plays the French

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 exd5 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Bd3 Bd6 6. O-O O-O 7. Bg5 Bg4 8. Nbd2 c5 9. c4 Nc6 10. dxc5 Bxc5

Authored anchor ends after 6... O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The King's Gambit requires ...e5. Against ...e6 this course offers a simple Exchange French bridge so you can reach a playable game without pretending to force the gambit.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the queen knight and bishop, then use the open e-file carefully. Study a separate French repertoire if this defense appears often in your games.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A symmetrical center does not mean a forced draw. Pins, attacks on h2 and h7, and central breaks still matter.

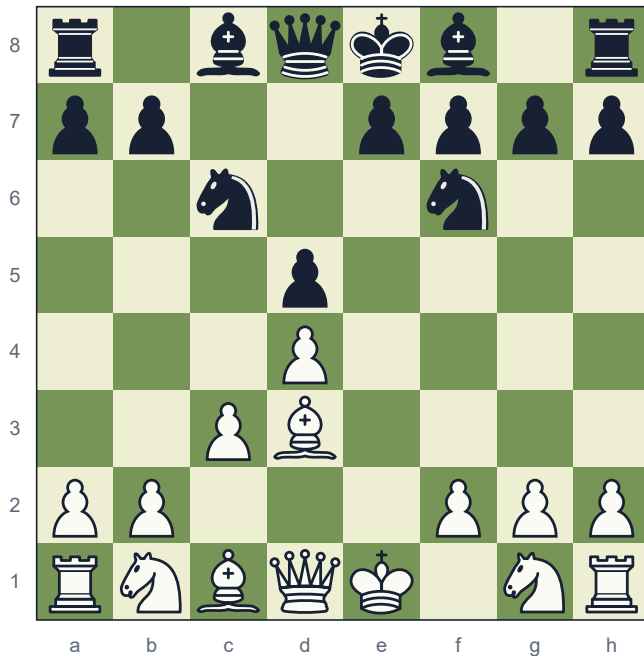
REMEMBER No ...e5 means no King's Gambit.

KG-29 / If Black plays the Caro-Kann

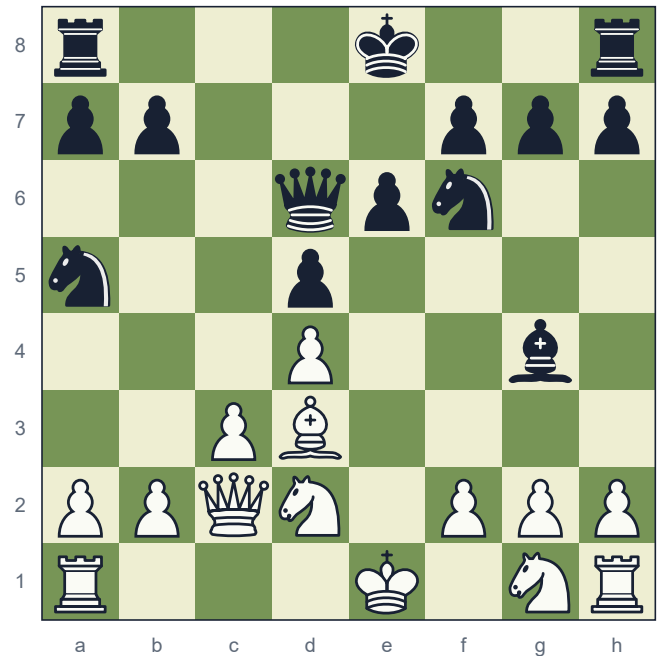
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 cxd5 4. Bd3 Nc6 5. c3 Nf6 6. Bf4 Bg4 7. Qb3 Na5 8. Qc2 e6 9. Nd2 Bd6 10. Bxd6 Qxd6

Authored anchor ends after 6. Bf4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The Exchange Caro-Kann bridge creates a clear pawn structure. Bf4 develops the queen bishop before e3 would block it.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Finish development and castle. Watch the c-file and choose a useful knight square without obstructing your own pieces.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can exchange the light-squared bishop or challenge the center. This is a companion starting line, not a complete Caro-Kann repertoire.

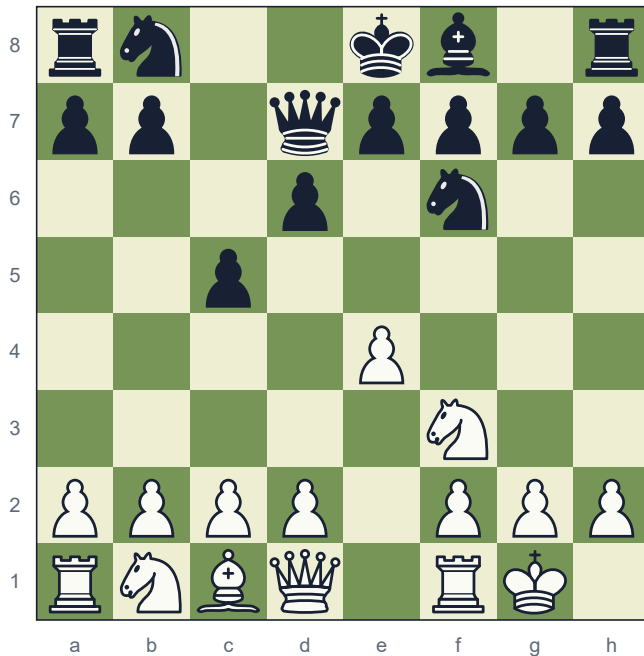
REMEMBER Choose a real response to Black's first move.

KG-30 / If Black plays the Sicilian

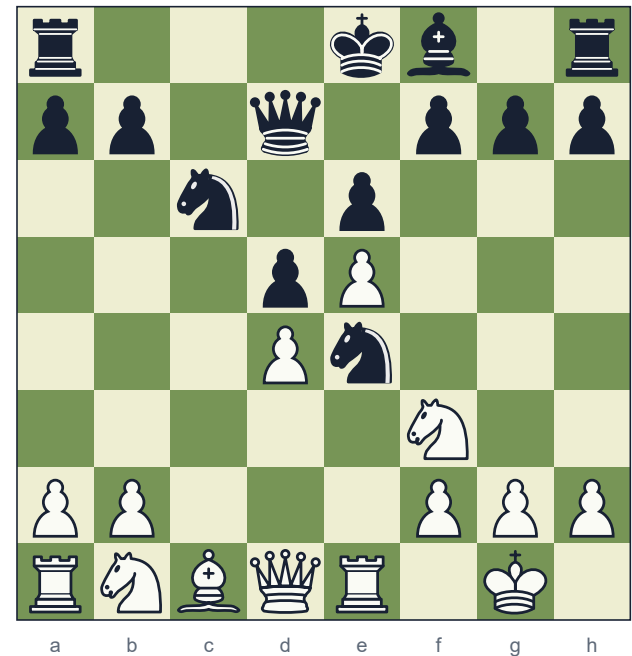
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. Bb5+ Bd7 4. Bxd7+ Qxd7 5. O-O Nf6 6. Re1 Nc6 7. c3 e6 8. d4 cxd4 9. cxd4 d5 10. e5 Ne4

Authored anchor ends after 6. Re1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Against ...d6 the check on b5 is a practical bridge. The bishop exchange simplifies development but gives up the bishop pair.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Build c3 and d4 if safe or choose d3 for a slower game. Against ...Nc6 or ...e6 use the separate bridge lessons in the study guide rather than forcing this exact check sequence.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's queen recapture affects d4 and the d-file. This line cannot stand in for all Sicilian variations.

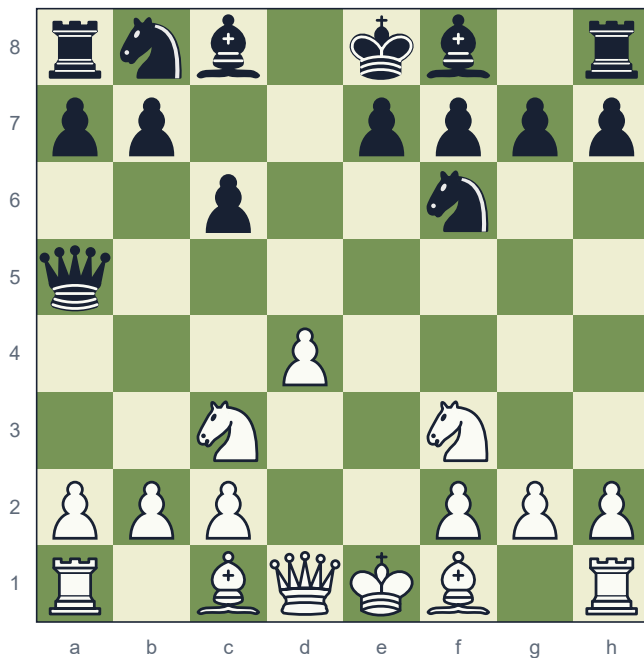
REMEMBER A bridge line has a defined move-order boundary.

KG-31 / If Black plays the Scandinavian

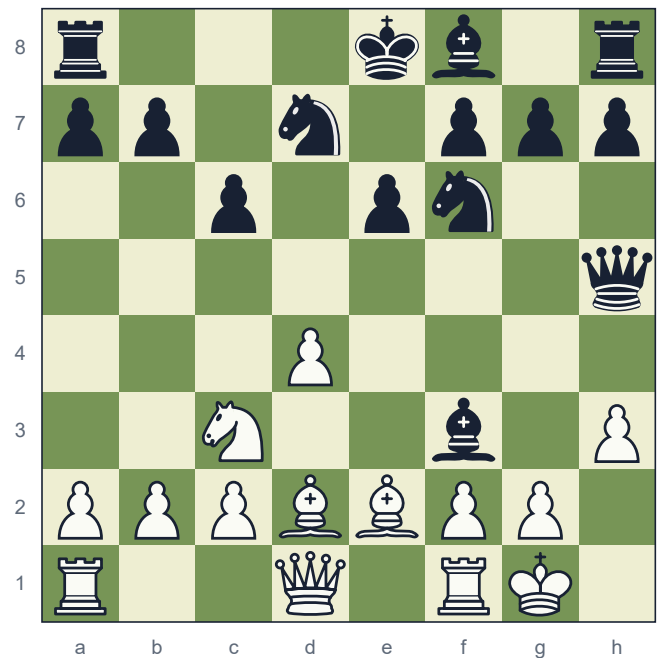
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bc4 Bg4 7. h3 Qh5 8. Be2 e6 9. Bd2 Nbd7 10. O-O Bxf3

Authored anchor ends after 6. Bc4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White gains a developing tempo against the queen and occupies the center. This normal response complements the gambit repertoire when Black immediately attacks e4.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Castle and develop the queen bishop, checking the a5-e1 diagonal before central tactics. Use your space rather than hunting the queen without purpose.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black often plays ...Bf5 and ...e6. A pin on the c3 knight can affect whether d4 is actually defended.

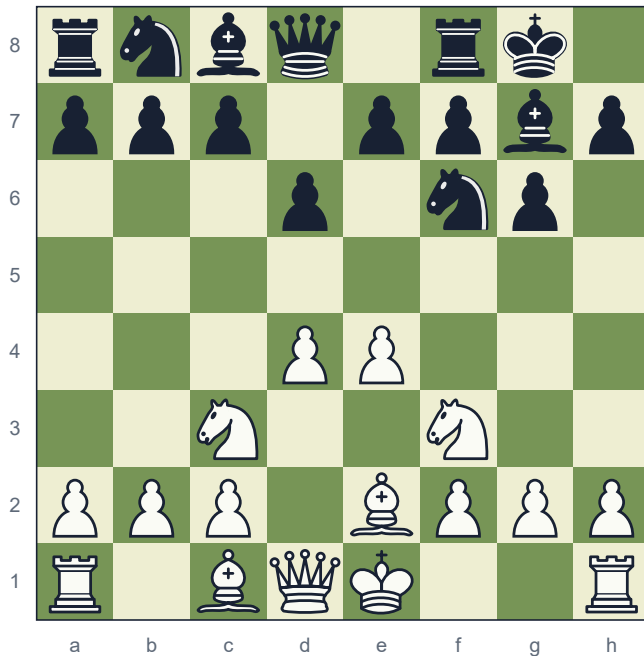
REMEMBER Meet a central challenge with development and calculation.

KG-32 / If Black plays a modern setup

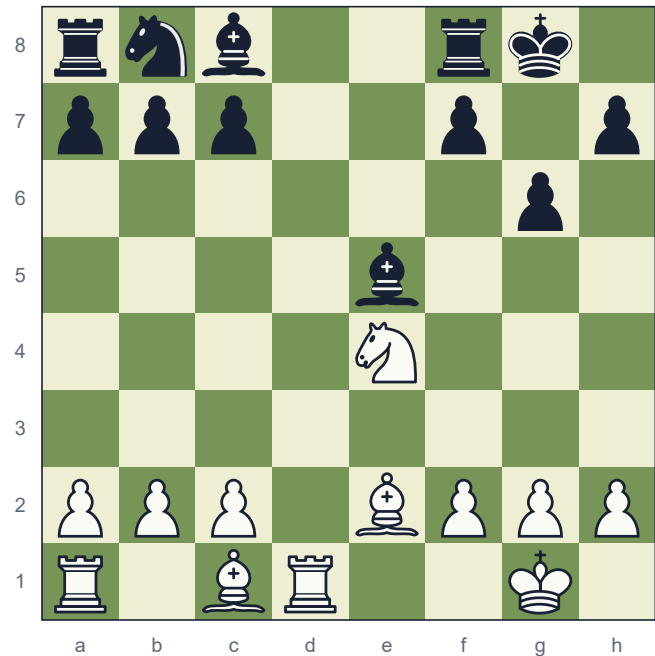
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Be2 O-O 6. O-O e5 7. dxe5 dxe5 8. Nxe5 Nxe4 9. Nxe4 Qxd1 10. Rxd1 Bxe5

Authored anchor ends after 6. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White takes the center and develops normally against a fianchetto. This bridge does not require sacrificing the f-pawn or launching an immediate attack.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and support e4 before choosing d5 or a kingside expansion. Black's ...c5 and ...e5 are the breaks to monitor.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A large center can become a target. The g7 bishop becomes active when central pawns exchange.

REMEMBER Take space, then make it sustainable.

Work through KG-25

7. D4

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

8. EXD5

The pawn captures a knight on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

9. QE2+

Gives check with the queen on e2. The opponent must answer the check; inspect legal king moves, captures and blocks.

10. NE5

Places the knight on e5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Bc4 develops before Nf3 and therefore permits the queen check. Kf1 preserves the center but gives up castling. This is an alternative to learn after the main repertoire. Develop Nf3 with a tempo against the queen if the position allows, then build d4 and coordinate the rook manually.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.